the November 2024 bypoll in the latter's Chauharsi stronghold, it was a matter of relief for the BJP when it narrowed BAP's win margin from 70,000 votes in 2023 to 25,000. But Patel still won Bagidora with over 50,000 votes. The seat was vacated by Congress MLA Mahendrajit Malviya, who defected to the BJP but lost to Rout in the LS faceoff at Banswara.

So this is sweet revenge. The BJP casts a cloud over the BAP's genesis, after splitting from the Gujarat-origin Bharat Tribal Party (BTP). Says BJP Banswara chief Punjalal Gayari, "The BTP supported the Gehlot regime in 2018-23, allegedly in exchange for cash. Its leaders dissolved the state BTP to launch BAP, driven by greed."

Takeaways

- **Young BAP MLA arrested in 'cash-for-query' scam. BJP goes to town with charges**
- **Since its 2023 debut, the BAP had emerged as a primary contender for tribal votes**

Rout says he'll move against Patel if the charges are proven, but hints at a conspiracy. "An MLA cannot withdraw a question once uploaded to the assembly portal. I need to determine whether Patel acted improperly or was falsely implicated," he says. Patel had submitted two questions each to the forest and mining departments: on mining leases, illegal mining, and construction of farmhouses in Todabhim, a far east constituency 700 km from Patel's Bagidora. The assembly had already received replies to the questions.

In a twist, the complainant is the son of BJP leader Ram Niwas Meena, who had lost Todabhim to the Congress's Ghanshyam Meher in 2023. Meena, also a tribal, says Patel was acting at Meher's behest to frame him and extort a bribe. Meher calls it "the lies of a sore loser". The BJP rejects this and is leveraging the case. There's also the BJP's track record of using threat and blandishment to wean worthy foes into its fold. So all eyes will be on whether the case is prosecuted in dead earnest—or whether there's a migratory bird on the horizon. ■

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

RAFALE KERFUFFLE

Ajay Rai gets some chilli in his eyes after a satirical send-up of Rajnath. The Congress battles to wash off 'sedition' stain, as Rai remonstrates ruefully

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

ANI



Takeaways

- **On May 4, just before Op. Sindoor, Rai holds up a toy Rafale to mock Rajnath**
- **Slapped with FIR, faces taunts of aiding Pakistani propaganda at wartime**

THE FRONTS HAVE FALLEN SILENT, but a piece of pre-war parodising has come back to smite the Congress on its rear. On May 4, a dozen days of non-action had elapsed since Pahalgam, and UP Congress chief Ajay Rai felt time was ripe for a satirical send-up of his state mate, Union defence minister Rajnath Singh. He held up a toy Rafale, with a *nimboo-mirchi* evil-eye dangling from it, and waxed vitriolic: "I want to ask the government when this lemon and chilli will be removed from the Rafale to avenge the attack?" It was a direct jibe at Rajnath's televised *shastra puja* in 2019, where he had placed a lemon under India's first Rafale fighter jet before drawing an 'Om' with turmeric on its snout.

Maybe the rumours of Rafales being felled had touched off rawer nerves, but in the volatile and charged political climate, Rai's gestures and words have sparked a storm that the party is now struggling to contain. The BJP moved in with its artillery and drones, calling the Congress "anti-national", and saying it was insulting India's military and aiding Pakistani propaganda. That knife got a keener edge after Pakistani media outlets gleefully swooped on Rai's parodic setpiece to play it up.

EXTRA MIRCHI FLAKES

Then, while Operation Sindoor was being unfurled across the border, things were turning hot as a tandoor for Rai. Exactly on May 7, an FIR was filed against him in Varanasi for "statements prejudicial to national integration", following a complaint by a Hindutva outfit. The complaint described his remarks as seditious. As wartime patriotism soared, the chronology proved particularly inauspicious for Rai. Politically, rather than a call for accountability, his statement was now being interpreted by many as undermining unity during a moment of national crisis.

Initially, he stood his ground, with fighting words like "I am just asking when Rafale will do its job". But he was soon scrambling to defend his nationalist credentials, saying he was proud of the military's courage and that he was critiquing the government. In Delhi, the Grand Old Party played scrupulously by the book, saying leaders often "speak for themselves and don't reflect the INC's views". ■